

Which Organizational Learning Disability Does Healthcare Suffer From Most?

The prompt makes a strong case for “I am my position,” and it is not wrong — but I would argue it is a symptom. The disability healthcare suffers from most is **the delusion of learning from experience**, and it generates the others.

Senge’s point is that we learn best from experience, yet we never directly experience the consequences of our most important decisions. Every organization has a **learning horizon**: the span in time and space within which results are observable. Healthcare’s is unusually short relative to how its decisions actually resolve. A nephrologist adjusts a peritoneal dialysis prescription at a monthly visit; the cyclor records the answer nightly for the next four weeks, and no one reads it until the following visit. Pronovost’s figure of roughly a 40% heart-failure readmission rate at 90 days is the same failure at scale — an enormous signal that is nearly invisible to the people generating it.

This is why it sits underneath the other disabilities rather than beside them. “I am my position” is what a short learning horizon feels like from the inside: if you can only observe your own slice, defining yourself by that slice is a rational adaptation. “Fixation on events” follows, because trends never return to you. The boiled frog is the terminal case.

A pathway. The fix is not training or better attitudes; it is engineering the feedback loop so that consequences reach the decision-maker while they can still teach. Pronovost’s catheter-infection work is the existence proof — unit-level rates fed back to the clinicians producing them, on a cadence short enough to connect action to outcome. Systems engineering formalizes exactly this: verification and validation are institutionalized feedback loops, and requirements traceability carries a consequence back to the decision that caused it. Concretely, for any recurring decision, find where its consequence actually lands and build a route back — and measure trends rather than incidents.

For the group: what decision do you make routinely whose consequence you have genuinely never observed?